its initial rise as a political force. The BJP's political fortunes started changing in 2014 only *after* it made a big shift in its caste strategy. It began embracing OBCs and sharing power with them in meaningful ways.

OBC Dominance in BJP's UP Lok Sabha Candidates from 2014 Onwards

This was most apparent in the big proportional shift on caste that the BJP made in candidates it fielded in the 2014 and 2019 general elections. The party had only put up fifteen OBC candidates out of eighty candidates in 2009 (see Table 3.1). In 2014, it significantly upped this to twenty-six OBCs, and then to twenty-nine in 2019. This made OBCs the single largest nominated caste category in the BJP's 2019 Lok Sabha candidates list, followed by Brahmins at eighteen (22.5 per cent) and Thakurs at thirteen (16.25 per cent). Furthermore, if we exclude the seventeen reserved SC seats in UP, OBCs (or the Mandal classes) made up a hefty 46 per cent of BJP candidates from general constituencies—almost half of its candidates. The rise in OBC numbers is significant because they are not fielded from reserved seats, unlike SC candidates, whom the party has to field anyway as seventeen (21.25 per cent) Lok Sabha seats in UP are reserved only for SC candidates. By fielding OBCs in such high numbers across two national elections (more than those fielded by any of its rival parties), the BJP was signalling a big shift in its caste orientation. Most of these candidates won. This shift in caste representation was central to the BJP's changed imagery in UP.

BJP Fielded More OBC Candidates Than Any Other Party in UP in 2017 Assembly Polls

The party made exactly the same caste shift towards OBCs in the 2017 assembly elections as well. It gave tickets to as many as 127 OBC (31.5 per cent) candidates (see Figure 3.3). Just as it did in 2014 and 2019 Lok Sabha elections, the rise of OBC candidates as the single biggest caste category for the BJP in the 2017 UP